PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

How to Build the Claim-Evidence Map

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Where we are going

1. What a claim-evidence map is — and **where it comes from**
2. Why it belongs in *comparative politics* specifically
3. The **anatomy** of one
4. How to build one, in six moves
5. A **worked example**: Kenya and Ghana
6. What separates a good map from a bad one

You will build one of these **for every numbered session**. They are ungraded — and they feed the quizzes, the cold calls, your presentations and your paper.

Part 1 — Where it comes from

An honest opening

"Claim-evidence map" is not a term with its own scholarly literature. It is a teaching device, assembled from two established sources.

Source 1 — Toulmin's layout of arguments

Stephen Toulmin, *The Uses of Argument* (Cambridge University Press, 1958; updated edition 2003).

Toulmin's insight: arguments have **functional parts**, and most disagreements are really disagreements about one particular part.

- **Claim** — what you are asserting
- **Data** — what you are asserting it on
- **Warrant** — why the data bears on the claim
- **Backing** — why the warrant itself holds
- **Modal qualifier** — how strongly you assert it
- **Rebuttal** — the conditions under which it would not hold

A note on terms: Toulmin wrote **data** in 1958. "Grounds" came later, in Toulmin, Rieke and Janik, *An Introduction to Reasoning* (1979). If you cite the 1958 book for "grounds," you will be citing it for something it does not say.

Source 2 — the Claim–Evidence–Reasoning framework

McNeill, Krajcik and Hershberger, *Supporting Grade 5–8 Students in Constructing Explanations in Science: The Claim, Evidence, and Reasoning Framework for Talk and Writing* (Pearson, 2011).

Three parts:

- **Claim** — a statement answering the question
- **Evidence** — data supporting the claim
- **Reasoning** — "a justification that shows why the data count as evidence to support the claim" (McNeill et al. 2006, p. 158)

That third element is Toulmin's **warrant** under another name. CER is a deliberate simplification — it drops the qualifier and the rebuttal.

Our version **puts them back**. In comparative politics you cannot afford to drop the rebuttal.

Does mapping actually work?

The claim that mapping improves reasoning is itself an empirical claim — so it should be treated like one.

- van Gelder (2005) argues gains come from **deliberate practice**, not exposure. Making the structure visible is what makes practice possible
- Twardy (2004) reports gains of roughly **0.7–0.85 standard deviations** across the Reason! studies, against about **0.3 SD** for typical critical-thinking instruction and about **0.34 SD** for a full first year of undergraduate education

For argument mapping in political science teaching specifically, see Rousseau and van Gelder (2025), *Journal of Political Science Education* 21(3): 406–422.

Part 2 — Why comparative politics?

Lijphart's problem, again

Recall the central methodological problem of the field: **too many explanatory variables, too few cases** (Lijphart 1971).

The statistical method

Controls for rival explanations **by design** — many cases absorb the work.

The comparative method

Two cases. Control comes from **case selection**, and everything else falls on **the quality of each inferential link**.

With a large N, a weak link is diluted. **With two cases, a weak link is the argument.**

So the map is not a study aid

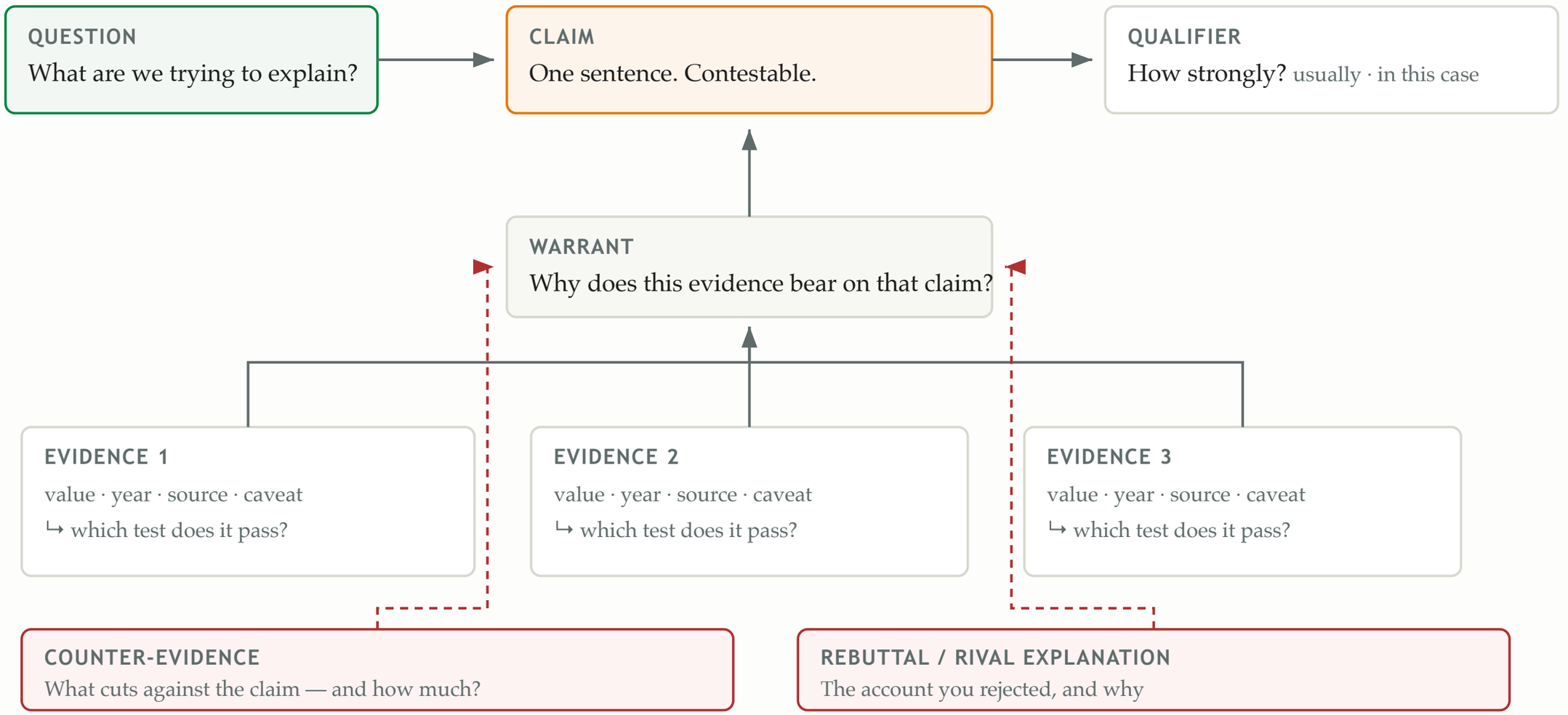
In a regression, the reader can inspect your specification. In a two-case comparison, the reader can only inspect **your reasoning** — if you have made it inspectable.

- It forces you to state the claim as **one contestable sentence**
- It forces every number to carry its **year, source and caveat**
- It forces you to name the **warrant** — the step students skip most often
- It forces you to write down the **counter-evidence** before you are attached to your answer

King, Keohane and Verba (1994) argue that qualitative and quantitative work answer to the **same standards of inference**. The map is how a two-case study meets them.

Part 3 — Anatomy

The anatomy of a claim-evidence map



The part everyone skips

The warrant. Students give a claim and three facts and believe they have argued something. They have not — they have **put a claim and some facts on the same page**.

The warrant answers: *why does this fact bear on that claim?*

No warrant

"Ghana has alternated four times. Kenya twice. Ghana has a presidential run-off."

Warrant supplied

"A run-off forces a losing plurality candidate to face a second contest he can win, which lowers the cost of accepting defeat the first time."

The second version can be **attacked**. That is what makes it an argument.

Not all evidence does the same work

Van Evera (1997, pp. 31–32) named the four tests; **Bennett** (2010, p. 210) recast them as a 2×2 on whether passing is **necessary** and/or **sufficient** for the inference; Collier (2011, p. 825) adapted that table. The necessary/sufficient framing is Bennett's, not Van Evera's.

SUFFICIENT for affirming the inference?

NECESSARY?	NO	YES
NO	**1 · Straw-in-the-wind** Pass → affirms relevance, does not confirm Fail → does not eliminate, slightly weakens The weakest evidence. Most of what students bring to Round 1 lives here — which is fine, so long as they say so.	**3 · Smoking gun** Pass → **confirms** the hypothesis Fail → does not eliminate, somewhat weakens Rare and powerful. Finding one is worth more than ten straws — but absence of a smoking gun proves very little.
YES	**2 · Hoop** Pass → affirms relevance, does not confirm Fail → **eliminates** the hypothesis The workhorse of comparative politics. Your explanation must jump through the hoop; clearing it does not make it true.	**4 · Doubly decisive** Pass → confirms, and eliminates rivals Fail → eliminates the hypothesis Almost never available in a small-N design. If you think you have one, you have probably misread the evidence.

Why the tests matter to you

An evidence row that does not say **what kind of work it does** is a row that has not been thought about.

- Most of what you find early is **straw-in-the-wind**. Say so — it is honest, not weak
- A **hoop test** is the most useful thing you can build: it lets you *eliminate* a rival explanation, and elimination is the scarcest good in a two-case design
- A **smoking gun** is worth ten straws — but its *absence* proves almost nothing
- If you think you have a **doubly decisive** test, you have probably misread the evidence

Part 4 — How to build one

Six moves

	Move	Test of whether you did it
1	Write the **question** the reading or the session poses	It ends in a question mark and is about *why*, not *what*
2	Write a **claim** — one sentence, contestable	Someone reasonable could disagree with it
3	List **evidence**, one row each: *value · year · source · caveat*	You opened every source yourself
4	Write the **warrant** under each row	It says *why this bears on that*, not what the fact is
5	Write the **counter-evidence** and the **rival explanation**	You can name what would make you abandon the claim
6	Add a **qualifier**	The claim is no longer stated more strongly than the evidence allows

The standing rule

Never write down a number you have not opened the source for. Every figure carries three things: **the year, the source, and the caveat.**

Your dossier is built to make this concrete: it reports figures that **disagree with each other**, and it ends with a page headed *"What we could not verify."*

A quotation that is not on the page you cite is a provable problem — whatever produced it.

Part 5 — A worked example

The question and the claim

Question. Why has Ghana alternated power four times since 1992 while Kenya has alternated twice?

> **Claim.** Ghana's presidential **run-off** lowers the cost of accepting defeat, which explains its more frequent peaceful alternations — while Kenya's single-round threshold with a county-distribution rule raises the stakes of the first count.

One sentence. Contestable. Names a **mechanism**, not a correlation.

The evidence rows

Evidence	Year · source	Caveat	Test
Ghana: 4 alternations (2000, 2008, 2016, 2024); Kenya: 2 (2002, 2022)	1992–2024 · electoral commissions	The outcome being explained, not evidence *for* the mechanism	—
Ghana has held **2 presidential run-offs** (2000, 2008); Kenya has held **0**	Dossier Kenya_Ghana	Both Ghanaian run-offs coincide with alternations — suggestive, and small n	Straw
Kenya's threshold: 50%+1 **and** 25% in 24 of 47 counties	Const. 2010, Art. 138(4)	A rule on paper; says nothing about behaviour	Hoop
Kenya 2007: 46.42% v. 44.07%, then mass violence; Waki Commission records **1,133 deaths**	2007–08 · Waki Commission	Contemporaneous estimates range 800–1,500	Straw
Kenya 2017: Supreme Court **annuls** a	1 Sept 2017	Cuts *against* — institutional accountability	Hoop (fails)

Evidence	Year · source	Caveat	Test
presidential election, 4–2		without a run-off	

Row 3 is the useful one. If Kenya had no distribution rule, the claim would be **eliminated**. It clears the hoop — which does not make it true.

The counter-evidence

Sequence. Ghana's peaceful alternations began in **2000** — *before* most of the institutional differences took their current form. Kenya's devolution began in **2013** — *after* the violence it was designed to prevent.

The opinion data cut the wrong way. Ghana scores far better on every expert measure — Freedom House 80/100 against Kenya's 49/100 in 2026. Yet on Afrobarometer Round 10, Ghanaians report **lower** satisfaction with democracy (49.2% v. 51%) and **lower** trust in the electoral commission (28.5% v. 36%).

Ghana's fieldwork closed *before* the December 2024 election and the alternation that followed — so the comparison is not clean. Say that out loud rather than hiding it.

The rival explanation

The institutional story

The run-off does the work.

The demographic rival

Ghana: Akan 45.7%; top three groups **78.1%**. **Kenya:** largest group 17.1%; top three **44.7%**.

One group near half the population makes two-party competition possible. Kenya's fragmentation makes coalitions necessary — ENPP ≈ **4.0** against Ghana's **1.83**.

Both ENPP figures are **the instructor's own Laakso–Taagepera calculations** from published seat counts, not published values. If you use them, present them as calculations.

The qualifier — and what it costs

Qualified claim. *In the Kenyan and Ghanaian cases since 1992,* run-off provisions **appear to be associated with** lower-cost alternation — but the association is **confounded by ethnic demography**, and the sequence of Ghana's alternations **precedes** the institutional differences invoked to explain them.

That is a weaker sentence than the one we started with. It is also the only one the evidence will carry.

Learning to write that sentence — and to be **unembarrassed by it** — is most of what this course is teaching.

Part 6 — Good maps and bad ones

The four failures

Failure	What it looks like	The fix
The topic, not the claim	"Devolution in Kenya"	A sentence someone could disagree with
Facts without warrants	Three true statements, no link	Under each row: *why does this bear on that?*
Naked numbers	"Gini 38.5"	*38.5, 2022, World Bank — Ghana's is 2016, six years apart*
No counter-evidence	Every row supports the claim	If you cannot say what would change your mind, you have a preference, not an argument

The fourth is the one that separates good teams from fluent ones.

What to carry forward

1. The map is **Toulmin's layout**, simplified by CER, with the **rebuttal put back**
2. It matters here because the comparative method has **too few cases to dilute a weak link**
3. The **warrant** is the part you will skip; write it anyway
4. Evidence is not uniform — ask what **work** each row does: straw, hoop, smoking gun
5. Every number carries **year, source, caveat**
6. Write the **counter-evidence before** you fall in love with the claim

References

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Resolving one of those rows, with a citation, is worth raising in Round 1. **It is exactly what the rubric rewards under *source practice*.**